



PAW & POCKET PRESENTS

The Dog Cost Cheat Sheet

What every dog *really* costs — the honest 2026 numbers, before you fall for the puppy photos.

6 breeds priced

The 5 hidden costs

Is insurance worth it?

Money-saving tips

pawandpocket.com · the honest pet-cost brand

SECTION 1

What six popular breeds really cost

Breeder puppy price, typical yearly cost, and the whole-life total — plus the one health cost that defines each breed.



Labrador

Puppy	\$800–\$2,500	Per year	\$1,700–\$2,900
Lifetime	\$27k–\$35k	Lives	10–13 yrs
Insure /mo	\$35–\$65		

Watch for: Hip & elbow joints, and a big appetite that piles on weight.



German Shepherd

Puppy	\$800–\$2,500	Per year	\$1,500–\$3,000
Lifetime	\$25k–\$40k	Lives	9–13 yrs
Insure /mo	\$40–\$75		

Watch for: Hip/elbow dysplasia, bloat, and degenerative myelopathy.



Golden Retriever

Puppy	\$1,000–\$3,500	Per year	\$2,000–\$3,500
Lifetime	\$20k–\$45k	Lives	10–12 yrs
Insure /mo	\$35–\$70		

Watch for: Cancer — ~60% lifetime risk; chemo runs \$7k–\$12k.



French Bulldog

Puppy	\$2,000–\$6,500	Per year	\$2,000–\$4,000
Lifetime	\$20k–\$40k	Lives	10–12 yrs
Insure /mo	\$40–\$80		

Watch for: Breathing (BOAS) surgery \$2k–\$5k; skin & spine issues.



English Bulldog

Puppy	\$1,500–\$4,500	Per year	\$2,000–\$4,000
Lifetime	\$22k–\$42k	Lives	8–10 yrs
Insure /mo	\$70–\$100		

Watch for: Airway + skin, highest hip-dysplasia rate, shortest life.



Cavalier K.C. Spaniel

Puppy	\$1,500–\$3,500	Per year	\$1,200–\$2,200+
Lifetime	\$15k–\$38k	Lives	9–14 yrs
Insure /mo	\$35–\$120		

Watch for: Heart disease (MVD) — near-certain with age.

SECTION 2

The 5 hidden costs nobody budgets for

The puppy price is the part everyone plans for. These are the parts that blindside people.

- 1. The day-one spike** Crate, bed, bowls, neutering, first vaccines and vet checks land all at once — budget \$500–\$1,200 before your dog has settled in.
- 2. Dental care** Cleanings and extractions add up, and skipping them leads to infections that cost far more later.
- 3. The emergency visit** A single after-hours emergency — a swallowed sock, a fall, a bad reaction — can run \$1,000–\$5,000 in one night.
- 4. Breed health conditions** The big one. Breed-specific surgery (airway, hips, heart, cancer) can be \$2,000–\$12,000+, and some breeds almost expect it.
- 5. Life admin** Boarding, dog-walking, replacing chewed beds and leads, pet deposits on rent — the quiet drip that never shows up in the puppy price.

Is insurance worth it? A 60-second checklist

- ✓ Enrol while your dog is young and healthy — pre-existing conditions are never covered.
- ✓ High-risk breed (Frenchie, Bulldog, Golden, Cavalier, Shepherd)? The maths leans toward yes.
- ✓ Couldn't comfortably absorb a surprise \$5,000 bill from savings? Insurance earns its place.
- ✓ Check the policy doesn't exclude the breed's signature condition (airway, hips, heart).
- ✓ Compare the three numbers that matter: annual limit, deductible, reimbursement %.

5 ways to spend less (without feeding worse)

- Buy larger bags and use subscribe-and-save — an easy 5–15% off food you'd buy anyway.
- Don't pay for marketing words — “grain-free”, “ancestral”, “artisan” rarely matter for a healthy dog.
- Keep them lean. Obesity quietly worsens (and pays for) almost every other problem.
- Insure early to lock in lower premiums before any condition appears.
- Adopt or rescue — often saves \$1,000+ and includes vaccinations and neutering.

Want *your* dog's exact number?

These are ranges. Our free calculator gives you a personalised lifetime figure — pick your size, food, and whether you'd insure, and watch the total update.

And for the full, honest breakdown on any of these breeds — health, insurance, the lot — the breed guides go deep.

Start free → pawandpocket.com

These figures are well-researched 2026 planning estimates, not quotes, and vary by breeder, location, and your individual dog. This sheet is general information, not financial or veterinary advice — always check with a professional. Paw & Pocket may earn a commission when you click through to a partner, at no extra cost to you. Paw & Pocket is a Periwinkle Network project; Periwinkle Network is a trading name of Cuning Corp.